Chapter Twenty-Nine

Sundiata of the Mali

Between 1203 and 1240,
the clans of the Malinke fight over
Ghana's land,
and the slave trade north grows

GHANA HAD FALLEN: first to Almoravid invasion and then to the rebellion of the Sosso, a once-subject clan in the south. Around 1203, just a few years after claiming the kingship of the Sosso clan itself, the clan chief Sumanguru overran the capital city of Kumbi-Saleh. The last remnants of Ghanan power fell into his hands; the entire country was his.

This must have been a great military campaign, but the warriors who fought with Sumanguru did not, like the chroniclers of the West, record its battles. All that we know of Sumanguru comes from the *Epic of Sundiata*, a tale told orally, for centuries, by professional bards known as *griots*. "He was skilled in warfare," the tale tells us,

> His father was a *jinn*,
> His mother was a human being. . . .
> The authority of kingship was given to him;
> His power as a king was great;
> He used to make hats out of human skin,
> He used to make sandals out of human skin.[1]